

RH07

Rajputana under the British; 19th-Century Conditions & Reform

About 1-2 questions a paper. The Walerkrit Rajputana Hitkarini Sabha alone gave three questions in RAS Pre 2024. The 1817-18 treaties and the social-reform years are the other two magnets.

This chapter answers one question: how did twenty-odd independent Rajput states end up as 'Rajputana Agency' on a British map? Then it asks a second: what did that century do to society inside those states. RPSC loves it because every fact here is a date attached to a place or a person — treaty years, abolition years, society years. Pure matching material.

Rajputana under the British

Entry

- Marathas & Pindaris
- Surji-Anjangaon 1803
- Treaties 1817-18
- Karauli first, Sirohi last

Machinery

- Rajputana Agency 1832
- AGG — Ajmer then Mount Abu 1845
- Political Agents
- Ajmer-Merwara = direct rule

Social evils ended

- Sati 1822 Bundi
- Infanticide 1833 Kota
- Tyag 1841 Jodhpur
- Dakan 1853 Mewar

Reform bodies

- Walter Sabha 1888 Ajmer
- Desh Hitaishini 1877 Udaipur
- Sarva Hitkarini 1907 Churu

Education & faith

- Mayo College 1875
- Dayanand & Arya Samaj
- Har Bilas Sharda

Stress

- Chhappaniya Akal 1899-1900
- Mer/Merwara 1820-22
- Railways from 1874

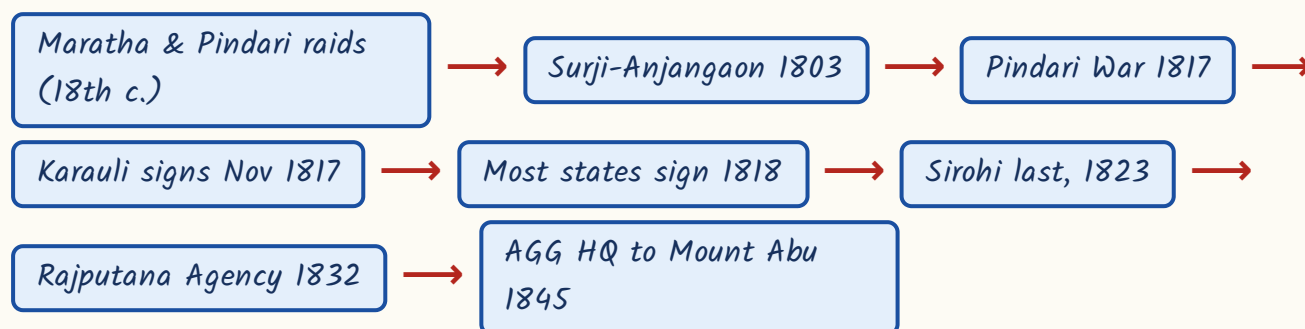
How the British walked in — Marathas first, then the Pindaris

Do not start this chapter with the British. Start with the Marathas. Through the eighteenth century the Scindias and Holkars raided Rajputana every year for tribute. Behind them came the Pindaris — irregular horsemen who plundered and left. The Rajput states were broke, exhausted and fighting each other.

So when the British offered protection, the states did not lose a war. They signed. That is the single most important idea in this chapter. The treaties of 1817-18 were bought with Maratha and Pindari pressure, not with British artillery.

- Treaty of Surji-Anjangaon, 30 December 1803, with Daulat Rao Scindia — this is the doorway.
- Ajmer itself passed to the British in 1818, ceded by Scindia.
- Governor-General at the time of the treaties: Lord Hastings.
- Negotiator on the British side for most of them: Sir Charles Metcalfe.
- The Third Anglo-Maratha and Pindari War (1817-18) is the immediate trigger.

From Maratha raids to British paramountcy



What did a state give up, and what did it keep? Learn this as a clean two-line answer. It gives away external relations and accepts British paramountcy. It keeps internal autonomy — its own courts, its own revenue, its own succession. Several states also agreed to pay tribute, called *khiraj*.

One caution on wording. These are subsidiary alliances in the Wellesley sense, but Rajputana signed under Hastings. If an option offers Lord Wellesley as the Governor-General, reject it.

The treaty order — the part RPSC actually asks

Two facts carry almost all the marks here. Karauli was first. Sirohi was last. Everything in between is a bonus. Learn the ends first, the middle later — and note that the two biggest states, Jodhpur and Udaipur, both signed in January 1818.

Subsidiary treaties with the British, in order of signing

State	Month & year
Karauli	November 1817 — FIRST
Tonk	November 1817
Kota	December 1817
Jodhpur (Marwar)	January 1818
Udaipur (Mewar)	January 1818
Bundi	February 1818
Bikaner	March 1818
Jaipur	April 1818
Jaisalmer	December 1818
Sirohi	1823 — LAST

- Tonk was created by the British in 1817 for the Pindari leader Amir Khan.
- Tonk was the only Muslim-ruled state of Rajputana.
- Jhalawar (1838), carved out of Kota, was the LAST princely state the British created in Rajputana.
- Sirohi's 1823 treaty is the usual 'NOT correctly matched' bait — options print 'Sirohi - 1818'.

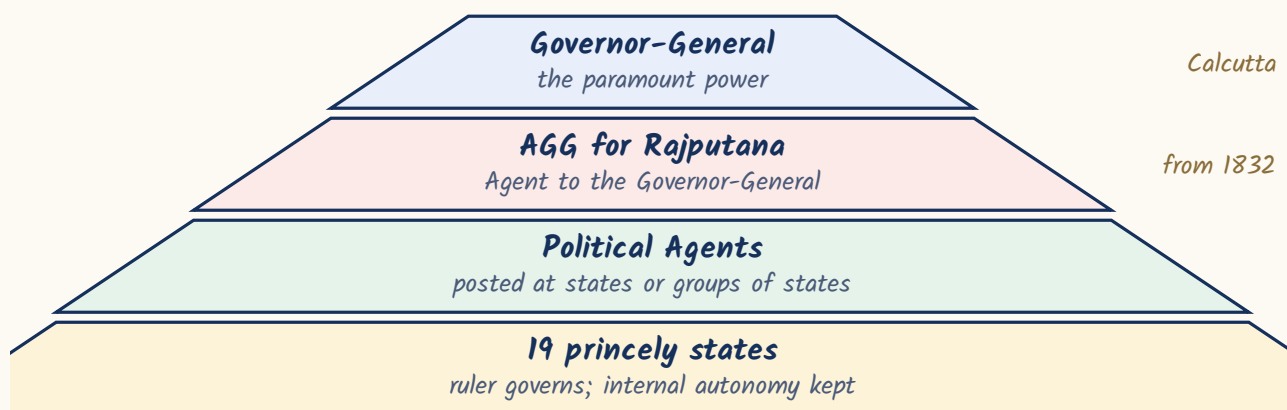
TRAP

Do not confuse the two 'last' facts. Sirohi = last state to SIGN a treaty (1823). Jhalawar = last state to be CREATED (1838).

The machinery of control — Agency, AGG, and Ajmer-Merwara

A treaty is paper. The British needed an office. That office is the Rajputana Agency, set up in 1832. Its head is the Agent to the Governor-General, the AGG. Under him sat Political Agents posted at individual states or groups of states.

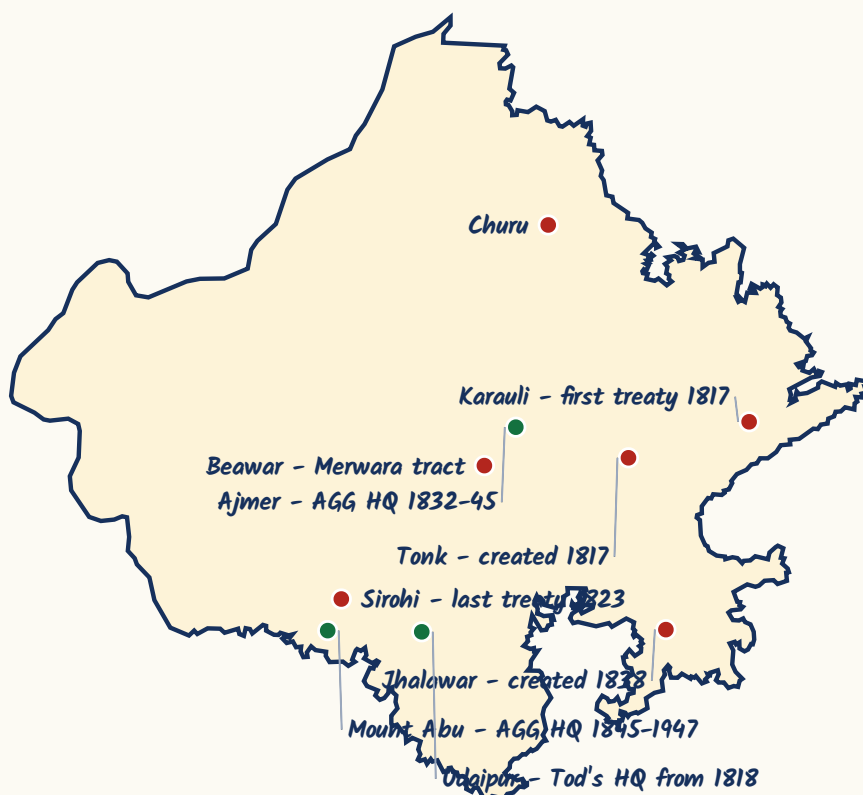
Who stood above whom in British Rajputana



- Rajputana Agency constituted: 1832.
- Head: Agent to the Governor-General (AGG) for Rajputana.
- HQ at Ajmer, 1832-1845.
- HQ shifted to Mount Abu in 1845 and stayed there till 1947.
- Mount Abu was leased by the British from Sirohi state — that is why a hill station became the AGG's seat.

Now separate two things that students keep merging. Princely Rajputana was indirectly ruled — the ruler governed, the Political Agent watched. Ajmer-Merwara was British territory, ruled directly by a Chief Commissioner. It was never a princely state.

The British map of Rajputana



Ajmer and Mount Abu were British seats; everything else was a princely capital

Princely Rajputana vs Ajmer-Merwara

Princely states (19 of them)	Ajmer-Merwara
Indirect rule — ruler governs	Direct British rule
Watched by AGG and Political Agents	Administered by a Chief Commissioner
Merged into Rajasthan 1948-49 in stages	Merged into Rajasthan on 1 Nov 1956
Became Part 'B' state territory in 1950	Was a Part 'C' state in 1950

TRAP

A favourite negative option: 'Ajmer-Merwara was administered by a princely ruler under its own treaty.' False. It was Chief Commissioner's territory, a Part 'C' state after 1950.

One more piece of pacification: the Mer tract of the Aravallis, Merwara. The Mers revolted in 1820-21. Colonel Hall put it down and the Merwara Battalion was raised in 1822 to police the hills permanently.

Colonel James Tod — the man who named 'Rajasthan'

Tod is a source-chapter name that keeps leaking into this chapter, so fix him here. He was Political Agent to the Western Rajput States from 1818, with headquarters at Udaipur. He wrote 'Annals and Antiquities of Rajast'han' — the book that gave the region its romantic image and, effectively, its modern name.

- James Tod — Political Agent, Western Rajput States, from 1818; HQ Udaipur.
- Work: 'Annals and Antiquities of Rajast'han'.
- He was an administrator-historian, not an educationist.

TRAP

Mayo College was NOT founded by James Tod. That pairing is planted in 'NOT correctly matched' questions almost every time Tod appears.

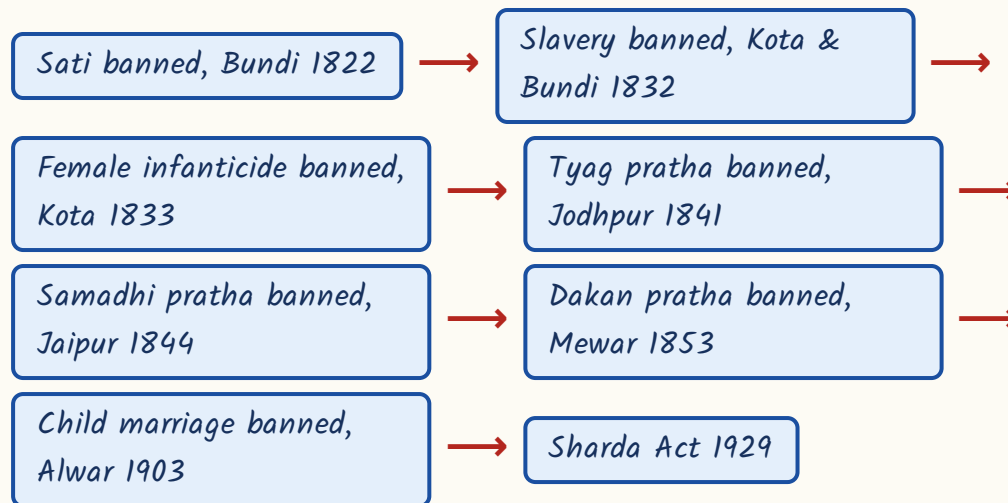
The social evils and the year each one fell

This is the highest-density table in the chapter. The pattern to internalise: in Rajputana the princely states banned these practices themselves, often BEFORE the British legislated for British India. Bundi outlawed sati in 1822 — seven years before Bentinck's Regulation of 1829. Remember that comparison; it is the point of the whole section.

Social practice — year abolished — state — ruler

Practice	Year	State	Ruler / note
Sati	1822	Bundi	Rao Vishnu Singh — first in Rajputana
Slavery (dasa pratha)	1832	Kota and Bundi	Declared illegal in both
Female infanticide (kanya vadh)	1833	Kota	Maharao Ram Singh — first ban
Female infanticide — rules framed	1839	Jodhpur	Follow-up to the Kota ban
Tyag pratha (Charan/Bhat wedding extortion)	1841	Jodhpur	Maharaja Man Singh
Samadhi pratha	1844	Jaipur	State prohibition
Dakan pratha (branding women as witches)	October 1853	Mewar	Maharana Swaroop Singh
Anmel vivah and child marriage	1903	Alwar	By state Act

Chronological order of reform measures — RPSC asks this as an ordering question



Two of these need a sentence of explanation, because a bare name teaches nothing. Tyag pratha was ritual extortion — Charans and Bhats would demand huge payments at weddings and threaten self-harm if refused. Dakan pratha was the practice of branding a woman a witch, usually to seize her land or settle a village quarrel, and then hounding or killing her.

- 1844 is the year usually given for the general prohibition of sati across the Rajputana states.
- Har Bilas Sharda of Ajmer piloted the Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929 — the 'Sharda Act'.
- Kanyavarodh — the killing or confinement of daughters — is the umbrella term for infanticide practices.
- Bentinck's all-India Regulation against sati is 1829; Bundi 1822 is seven years earlier.

YAAD RAKHO

Four dates, four states, in rising order: 22-Bundi (sati), 33-Kota (infanticide), 41-Jodhpur (tyag), 53-Mewar (dakan). Say it as 'Bundi-Kota-Jodhpur-Mewar' and the years follow.

The reform societies — Walter Sabha above all

If you learn one institution from this chapter, learn the Walterkrit Rajputana Hitkarini Sabha. RPSC asked three separate questions on it in 2024 — its year, its founder and what it did NOT do. Colonel C.K.M. Walter, the AGG of Rajputana, founded it at Ajmer in 1888. It was originally called simply the Rajputana Hitkarini Sabha; 'Walterkrit' means 'created by Walter'.

Its whole purpose was to stop Rajput families from ruining themselves on ceremony. Marriage spending, death feasts, dowry, polygamy, child marriage. It was a social body working through the princes — not a political one.

- Curb marriage expenditure and the death feast (nukta / mrityu bhoj).
- End dowry and polygamy.
- Fix minimum marriage age: 14 for girls, 18 for boys.
- It did NOT campaign for widow remarriage.
- It did NOT seek political representation for the people.

Reform bodies of 19th-century Rajputana

Body	Year	Place	Founder / patron
Desh Hitaishini Sabha	1877	Udaipur	Maharana Sajjan Singh
Walterkrit Rajputana Hitkarini Sabha	1888	Ajmer	Colonel C.K.M. Walter, AGG
Sarva Hitkarini Sabha	1907	Churu	Swami Gopal Das (with Pt. Kanhaiyalal, Pt. Shriram)

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — the Walterkrit Rajputana Hitkarini Sabha, founded in 1888, had its headquarters at? Answer: Ajmer.

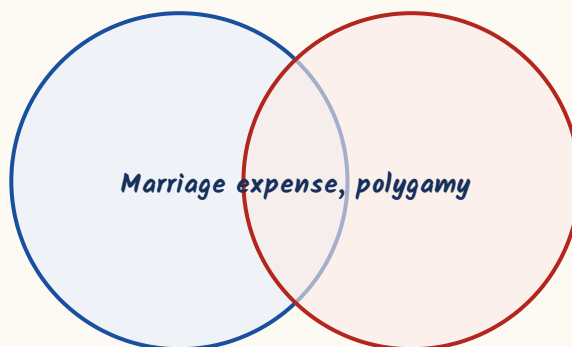
ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 — who founded the Walterkrit Rajputana Hitkarini Sabha? Answer: Colonel C.K.M. Walter, the AGG of Rajputana.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 as a negative question — which was NOT an objective of the Walter Sabha? Answer: securing political representation for the people of the states. It was purely social.

Watch the Desh Hitaishini Sabha carefully. It attacked the same evils — marriage expenditure and polygamy — but eleven years earlier, at Udaipur, under Maharana Sajjan Singh. Similar aims, different year and different town. That is exactly what a matching question is built on.

Two reform sabhas that look alike**Desh Hitaishini Sabha****Walterkrit Hitkarini Sabha**

Udaipur 1877 under Maharana Sajjan Singh; Ajmer 1888 under Colonel C.K.M. Walter

Education, religion, famine and the railway

The British answer to 'how do we civilise the princes' was a boarding school. Mayo College opened at Ajmer in 1875, named after Viceroy Lord Mayo, and was built for the sons of princes and nobles. It is nicknamed the 'Eton of the East'.

- Mayo College — Ajmer, 1875, named after Lord Mayo.
- Purpose: educate Rajput princes and nobles in English lines.
- Nickname: 'Eton of the East'.

CURRENT LINK

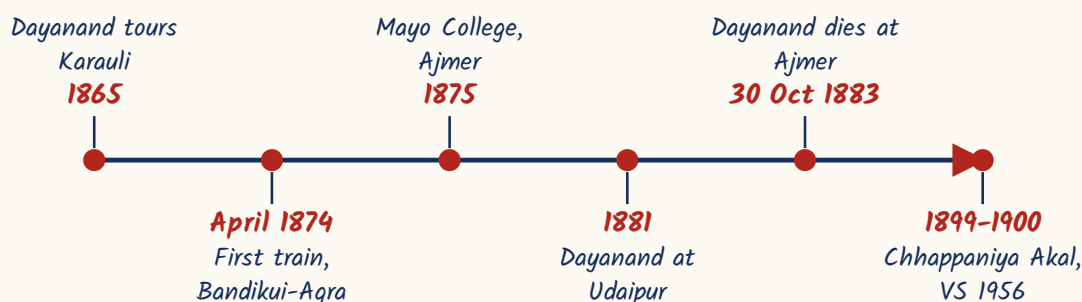
Current link (as of September 2026): Mayo College completed 150 years in 2025 and held sesquicentennial celebrations through the year. An anniversary year is exactly when RPSC picks up an institution — keep 1875 and Lord Mayo ready.

The other current running through the century is religious reform. Swami Dayanand Saraswati, founder of the Arya Samaj, toured Rajputana repeatedly and found patrons among the princes. His Rajasthan connection is examinable in two specific places.

- Dayanand's tours: Karauli 1865; later Ajmer, Bharatpur and Udaipur in 1881.
- He revised the Satyarth Prakash at Naulakha Mahal, Udaipur, as Maharana Sajjan Singh's guest.
- He died at AJMER on 30 October 1883.
- His Paropkarini Sabha continues at Ajmer — Ajmer is the answer both for his death and for that Sabha.

Finally, the two material shocks of the period. Famine, and the railway. The Chhappaniya Akal — the famine of Vikram Samvat 1956, that is 1899-1900 — was the worst in Rajputana's recorded history, and 'chhappaniya' has since become the Rajasthani word for total ruin. The railway arrived a generation earlier: the first train in Rajputana ran from Bandikui to Agra Fort in April 1874, on the metre-gauge line that grew into the Rajputana-Malwa Railway.

The late nineteenth century in Rajputana



YAAD RAKHO

Chhappan = 56. Vikram Samvat 1956 = CE 1899-1900. If you can convert the name to the number, you never lose this date.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): the line that starts with Har Bilas Sharda of Ajmer is still live. In October 2024 the Supreme Court, in the child marriage case brought by the Society for Enlightenment and Voluntary Action, issued detailed directions to states for enforcing the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006 - community-level monitoring, child marriage prohibition officers and prevention over prosecution. If a paper pairs a reformer with a statute, the Ajmer link is Har Bilas Sharda and the Child Marriage Restraint Act, 1929.

REVISION RECAP

1. Surji-Anjangaon, 30 Dec 1803, with Daulat Rao Scindia opens Rajputana; Ajmer to the British in 1818.
2. Karauli (Nov 1817) first to sign a subsidiary treaty; Sirohi (1823) last.
3. Metcalfe negotiated; Lord Hastings was Governor-General.
4. Treaty bargain: external relations and paramountcy to the British, internal autonomy kept, khiraj paid.
5. Tonk created 1817 for Pindari chief Amir Khan — the only Muslim state of Rajputana.
6. Jhalawar 1838, carved from Kota — last state created by the British here.
7. Rajputana Agency 1832; AGG at Ajmer till 1845, then Mount Abu (leased from Sirohi) till 1947.
8. Ajmer-Merwara = direct British rule, Chief Commissioner, Part 'C' state 1950, into Rajasthan 1 Nov 1956.
9. James Tod — Political Agent, Western Rajput States, 1818, HQ Udaipur; 'Annals and Antiquities of Rajast'han'.
10. Sati 1822 Bundi (Rao Vishnu Singh); slavery 1832 Kota and Bundi.
11. Female infanticide 1833 Kota (Maharao Ram Singh); Jodhpur rules 1839.
12. Tyag pratha 1841 Jodhpur (Man Singh); samadhi pratha 1844 Jaipur; dakan pratha Oct 1853 Mewar (Swaroop Singh).
13. Anmel vivah and child marriage banned by Alwar Act 1903; Sharda Act 1929 by Har Bilas Sharda of Ajmer.
14. Walter Sabha 1888, Ajmer, Colonel C.K.M. Walter — social not political; marriage age 14 girls / 18 boys.
15. Desh Hitaishini Sabha 1877 Udaipur (Sajjan Singh); Sarva Hitkarini Sabha 1907 Churu (Swami Gopal Das).
16. Mayo College Ajmer 1875, after Lord Mayo, 'Eton of the East'.
17. Dayanand revised Satyarth Prakash at Naulakha Mahal Udaipur; died Ajmer 30 Oct 1883.
18. Chhappaniya Akal = VS 1956 = 1899-1900, worst famine on record.
19. Mer revolt 1820-21 crushed by Colonel Hall; Merwara Battalion raised 1822. First train: Bandikui-Agra Fort, April 1874.